

Where NYC's 311 System Gets Stuck

One-page insights memo · Solomon Shasanmi · Data through early October 2026

The big idea: New York answers most 311 requests fast, but a few agencies are drowning in old requests, and the busiest problems show up on a calendar you can predict. The fix is less about working harder and more about planning ahead.

What I did

I pulled every 311 request from the past 13 months (about 4.3 million) from the city's open-data API, cleaned it with Python, and built a Power BI dashboard that refreshes itself every morning. One catch I had to work around: brand-new requests make the city look faster than it is, because only the quick ones have closed yet. It's like grading a class on the tests that were handed in first. So my response times only count requests that have had at least 30 days to close.

4.3M

requests in 13 months

80%

closed within a week

209K

still open today

Half

of those are 90+ days old

What I found

1. **"Average" hides the real story.** The police handle almost half of all requests and close them within hours, which makes the citywide average look great. Parks closes fewer than 4 in 10 requests within a week, and Taxi & Limousine fewer than 2 in 10.
2. **The backlog is old, not just big.** Half of the open requests have waited over three months, mostly at Parks, Housing, Taxi & Limousine and Transportation.
3. **Complaints follow the seasons, like ice-cream sales in reverse.** Heat complaints jump about 20 times from September to January. Street and pothole complaints doubled in March, when winter damage showed up.
4. **Manhattan is the slowest borough** at about 8 days to close a request, even though Brooklyn files the most.

What I'd recommend

1. **Staff up for heat before winter:** extra Housing inspectors from October to February.
2. **Dig into Manhattan's delays** by agency and complaint type to find which team drives the gap.
3. **Get ahead of the March pothole wave:** move Transportation crews and budget before the thaw.
4. **Run a 90-day backlog review** at the four agencies holding most of the old requests: close what's done, re-assign what isn't.

So what? The city doesn't have a 311 problem; it has a handful of predictable pressure points. Planning staff around the calendar and clearing old requests would make the system feel faster to the people waiting the longest.

Data: NYC Open Data, 311 Service Requests (dataset erm2-nwe9). "Closed" can mean referred or not found, so this measures speed, not quality. Full dashboard, code and method: github.com/TheeGreenGenie/NYC-311-Power-BI